The Slavs and the Rest of the Eastern Europeans

On our short journey through the history of Eastern Europe we now move from late antiquity to early middle ages. Things turned sour for Europe in the sixth century with the arrival of the Slavs, feared by both Germanic people and by the Byzantines. We do not know for sure whether violence against the old settlers (Germanic peoples, Greeks, Romans and other Romanised native peoples) was the dominant pattern when the Slavs moved in. There are also suggestions that, at least in some instances, they integrated into existing societies culturally, even when they prevailed ethnically. In any event they drew another wedge between the Franks and the Byzantines, obstructing the lines of communication between the two civilisations and the two superpowers of the day.[13]

With their arrival, Slavs became the dominant element in Eastern Europe and they have been so ever since, despite the fact that there are a number of non-Slav peoples in Eastern Europe: none of the peoples of the Baltic nations is Slav, nor are the Hungarians, the Romanians or the Albanians. The Greeks – the ultimate Eastern Europeans – are not Slavs.

Nor can the (mostly Slavic) world east of the former Iron Curtain be simply reduced to a Russian influence zone, despite Russia's crucial (and sometimes brutal) role in the region in modern history. In fact, Russia only significantly entered the general history of Eastern Europe at quite a late date, not much before the reign of Peter the Great in the last decades of the seventeenth century. (Although Lithuanians and Poles, who had established a commonwealth which was a key player in the region stretching from the Baltic to the Black Sea in the Middle Ages, were at loggerheads with their Eastern neighbours centuries earlier.) Peter the Great started building cultural ties with Western Europe at much the same time as he also began his territorial expansion to the West, with the Poles, the Baltic nations and the Finns being its first victims. From then on, Russia would continue to be seen as a threat to them.

After Christianisation, Poles and Czechs continued to enjoy relative political autonomy. This was not the case for Slovenians, who were soon submerged into Charlemagne's empire, or for Slovaks who came under